

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BRUNEI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Brunei is one of the very richest nations on earth per person, its wealth drawn almost entirely from the offshore oil and gas beneath its coastal waters — and, unusually, it has kept more than seventy percent of its land under rainforest, protected well over half its territory, joined the tri-national **Heart of Borneo** effort, and lets its forests absorb almost all of its own emissions. This is a real and genuinely rare achievement, especially on an island whose forests have elsewhere been so heavily felled, and this guide honours it plainly. But the same nation is almost wholly dependent on the oil and gas whose burning drives the climate crisis, and now anchors a growing **petrochemical and plastics industry** it calls diversification but that keeps it tied to fossil fuels — even as its forests and coasts face the ordinary pressures of development. And Brunei is an absolute monarchy, among the most politically closed nations anywhere, where open dissent is essentially impossible and criticism of the ruler and the royal family is simply not permitted. There is no landmark community victory to point to, and no one inside can openly resist.

Those who care about Brunei's environment cannot organise openly, but a green-conscious state that values its conservation record gives real, if narrow, levers — all worked through the state's own aims, never as opposition. The government's **own green commitments and conservation pledges** — the frameworks, the targets, the protected forest — are pledges it can be held to and measured against, on its own terms. The **contradiction between the petrochemical turn and the green image** is an evidence-based argument: doubling down on plastics and fossil fuels sits ill with the conservation brand the state prizes, and true diversification lies elsewhere. The **international frameworks Brunei has joined** — the tri-national Heart of Borneo and the global climate and conservation regimes — carry commitments and reputational stakes a case can invoke. And **science, technical institutions, and the language of stewardship** are channels a closed state permits, where an environmental case can be made safely. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Brunei is an absolute monarchy among the most closed states in the world: open dissent is impossible, criticism of the ruler and royal family is not permitted, and the red lines around the monarchy, religion, and politics are absolute. The oil dependence is real and diversification genuinely hard. There is no domestic space for opposition and no landmark victory to point to. And no one can be exposed. So the work must run only through the state's own aims, the international frameworks, and the language of stewardship — never as criticism or dissent, and protecting everyone involved absolutely — and the honest prize is the forest defended and extended, the green commitments upheld, and the worst pressures eased, all on the state's own terms, not an open stop.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot organise openly, and you must never frame anything as opposition, criticism, or dissent. What can be done is to work entirely through the state's own conservation aims: hold the government to its green commitments and international frameworks, make the evidence-based case that the petrochemical turn contradicts its own green image, and press through the permitted channels of science and stewardship — all in the state's own language, and protecting everyone involved absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Brunei is one of the most closed settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win by opposition — opposition is impossible and dangerous. It is a stewardship effort worked through the state's own aims, whose realistic prize is the forest defended and extended and the green commitments upheld, on the state's own terms. And, distinctively, the state genuinely values conservation, which gives the effort real ground — but only if it is never framed as criticism, and only if everyone involved is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests absolutely with the monarchy, in a closed state where dissent is impossible and criticism of the ruler is not permitted. But the state genuinely prizes its conservation record, so the decisions a careful effort can reach are those framed as advancing the state's own green aims: the **conservation and forestry authorities**, the **technical and scientific institutions** the state permits, and the **international frameworks** Brunei has joined and values. The channels that matter are stewardship, science, and the state's own commitments — never opposition.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

Development advances by state decision. There is no domestic hearing to contest, and no open objection to lodge. Where a careful effort enters is on the state's own terms: showing how a harm contradicts the conservation record the state prizes, how the petrochemical turn sits ill with its green image, how the international frameworks it values bear on the matter. The entry point is always the alignment — or the gap — between the harm and the state's own stated aims.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the forest: what protection and commitments the state has made, and whether a project honours them. Follow the diversification: whether the petrochemical turn advances or contradicts the state's green image and its stated future. Follow the frameworks: which international commitments Brunei has joined and values. The leverage lies in the state's own aims, the reputational stakes of its frameworks, and the contradiction the petrochemical turn creates.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is minimal in a closed state, but the state's own conservation and forestry bodies, its technical and scientific institutions, and the international frameworks it has joined are the channels a stewardship case engages — holding the state, on its own terms and its own record, to what it has said.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Bruneian effort yields an open "win," and honesty requires saying so — there is no domestic space and no landmark victory. What the levers realistically deliver, all on the state's own terms, is the forest defended and extended, a green commitment upheld, a petrochemical excess questioned as inconsistent with the state's own aims. The single most decisive move is **framing everything as advancing the state's own conservation record and commitments**, because that is the one register a closed but green-conscious state permits, and the one that keeps everyone safe. The state's green commitments are the strongest lever; the diversification contradiction the sharpest argument; the international frameworks the reputational

stake. Nothing here is open or fast — but a state that prizes its forest can be held, quietly, to that pride.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the forest or coast pressured, the petrochemical or development footprint, the emissions. **Which state aim does it touch?** — the conservation record, the green commitments, the international frameworks. **What is the contradiction?** — where the harm sits ill with the state's own green image and stated future. **Which permitted channel reaches it?** — the conservation bodies, the technical institutions, the stewardship framing. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by working only through the state's aims and never as opposition. Pick the harm where the gap between it and the state's own conservation pride is clearest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all in the language of stewardship. **Layer one: the harm and the state's aim** — the forest, coast, or emissions at stake, and the state's own conservation record and commitments the harm strains. **Layer two: the contradiction and the framework** — how the harm sits ill with the green image and the international frameworks Brunei values. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which permitted conservation, scientific, or stewardship channel to reach, and the absolute rule of never framing anything as criticism and never exposing anyone. A case built entirely on advancing the state's own conservation aims — technical, respectful, and stewardship-framed — is the one a closed state permits and the one that keeps everyone safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **state-aim record**: the conservation commitments, the protected-forest record, the green targets, the international frameworks Brunei has joined. Gather the **harm record**: the forest or coastal pressure, the petrochemical and plastics footprint, the emissions. Gather the **contradiction record**: where the petrochemical turn sits ill with the green image and the stated future. Gather the **channel record**: the conservation and technical institutions, the scientific and stewardship networks, the international framework bodies. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm everything is framed as stewardship, never opposition, and that no one is exposed.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE STEWARDSHIP COALITION

The coalition here is not an opposition — it cannot be — but a stewardship one, aligned with the state's own aims. Build it, carefully, from the **conservation and technical institutions** the state permits, the **scientists and stewardship voices**, and the **international framework partners** who share the conservation cause. Frame the whole effort as advancing Brunei's own record and commitments, never as criticism; involve no one who could be endangered; and keep entirely to the environmental and stewardship domain, away from anything political.

STEP 4: THE STATE'S AIMS, FRAMEWORKS & STEWARDSHIP — CONTESTING THE HARM ON THE STATE'S OWN TERMS

Set expectations honestly: the levers are narrow, worked only through the state's aims, and the prize is the forest defended and the worst pressures eased, not an open stop.

The State's Own Green Commitments

The government's **conservation record and green commitments** — the protected forest, the targets, the pledges — are the strongest lever, because they are the state's own, made on its own terms and prized as a rare achievement. Hold the state, quietly and respectfully, to what it has said, and press for the forest to be defended and extended as the state itself has committed.

The Diversification Contradiction

The **contradiction between the petrochemical turn and the green image** is the sharpest argument: doubling down on plastics and fossil fuels sits ill with the conservation brand the state prizes, and genuine diversification lies elsewhere. Make it, on the state's own terms, as a matter of consistency with its own stated aims.

The International Frameworks and Stewardship Channels

The **international frameworks Brunei has joined** — Heart of Borneo and the global climate and conservation regimes — carry commitments and reputational stakes a case can invoke, and **science and stewardship** are the channels a closed state permits. Pursued together — the state's commitments, the contradiction, and the frameworks — these levers defend the forest and ease the worst pressures on the state's own terms, while everyone involved is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to the state's own aims. **For the conservation and forestry bodies:** here is a harm that strains the protected-forest record the nation is rightly proud of. **For the state's green image:** here is where the petrochemical turn sits ill with the conservation brand and the stated future. **For the international frameworks:** here is a matter that bears on the Heart of Borneo and the global commitments Brunei values. **For the scientists and stewards:** here is the technical case to carry, in the language of stewardship. **The golden rule:** frame everything as advancing the state's own conservation aims, never as opposition or criticism, and protect everyone involved absolutely — that is the only safe and effective register here.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and never as domestic dissent. Frame any external attention around Brunei's **conservation record and its green commitments** — honouring the achievement, and noting, on the state's own terms, where the petrochemical turn sits ill with it. Carry it through international conservation, scientific, and stewardship channels, never through anything that reads as criticism of the state or the ruler. A few cautions govern everything: never frame it as opposition; keep strictly to stewardship and science; protect everyone; and let the state's own commitments and the contradiction carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message stewardship-framed, respectful of the state's aims, and absolutely protective of anyone involved.

8A — To a conservation or forestry authority: honour the protected-forest record and note, respectfully, the harm that strains it, on the state's own terms.

8B — To a technical or scientific institution: present the stewardship case and request technical assessment.

8C — To an international framework partner (Heart of Borneo): connect the matter to the shared conservation commitment and ask for engagement.

8D — To a global climate or conservation body: set out the matter as it bears on Brunei's own commitments.

8E — On the diversification contradiction: make the consistency argument — that the petrochemical turn sits ill with the state's green aims — respectfully and on the state's own terms.

8F — To the stewardship and scientific networks: share the technical case and ask for support.

8G — To an international conservation ally: share the documented, stewardship-framed case and ask for careful amplification.

8H — To the international public: honour the conservation achievement and note the contradiction — never as criticism — and ask for attention, without exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the state's own conservation commitments and the harm that strains them; write the one-page stewardship case, framed entirely on the state's aims; identify the safest channel — usually a conservation body or an international framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the state's own green commitments, the diversification contradiction, and the international frameworks. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the conservation institutions and the international partners first, in the language of stewardship. Throughout, never frame anything as opposition, and protect everyone.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and absolute: a monarchy where dissent is impossible. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but the forest defended and the worst pressures eased, on the state's own terms. Lean on the one register the closure permits: the state's own conservation aims, its green commitments, its international frameworks, its stewardship channels. And accept the honest limits — the oil dependence is real, diversification hard, and no landmark victory is to be won — while still holding the state, quietly, to the conservation record it prizes, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a closed monarchy, questions of power and benefit cannot be pursued openly and must never be. Where a harm seems to serve private interests, respond only through the **stewardship and international channels** — the state's own conservation aims, the frameworks, the technical case — never through anything that touches the monarchy, religion, or politics. **On safety and the greatest care:** this note matters most of all. Brunei is an absolute monarchy among the most closed states in the world, where the red lines around the monarchy, religion, and politics are absolute. Work only through the state's own aims, the international frameworks, and the language of stewardship; never frame anything as opposition, criticism, or

dissent; protect everyone involved absolutely and involve no one who could be endangered; keep entirely to the environmental and stewardship domain; and handle the monarchy, religion, and all sensitive matters with the utmost discretion and respect. The greatest care here is not caution but necessity.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all in the language of stewardship. The state's own commitments and the documented harm feed the consistency argument, the diversification contradiction, and the international-framework case at once; the stewardship coalition organises carefully alongside; any external attention honours the conservation record throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the state's aims and the harm that strains them; **months two to six**, engage the conservation bodies, the technical institutions, and the international frameworks, all on the state's own terms; **beyond**, sustain the quiet, stewardship-framed pressure toward the forest defended and the worst pressures eased. The core discipline: state's-own-aims, stewardship-framed, never opposition, and absolute in protecting everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Brunei is among the most closed grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim that opposition is possible, or that the ruler can be criticised, or that there is domestic space to resist — none of that is true. But it honours, plainly, a real and rare achievement: a wealthy oil nation that has kept the great majority of its forest standing. And it claims something narrower and real: that a state which genuinely prizes its conservation record can be held, quietly and on its own terms, to the green commitments it has made and the international frameworks it values; that the petrochemical turn creates a real contradiction with its own green image; and that all of this can be pursued through the permitted channels of science and stewardship — never as criticism, and never exposing anyone. The levers are narrow, worked entirely through the state's aims, and the prize is the forest defended and extended and the worst pressures eased, not an open stop. But in a closed but green-conscious monarchy, that quiet, respectful, stewardship-framed work — honouring the achievement and holding the state to it — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.